CURRENT AND FUTURE GENERATION

Nuclear Energy and Public Opinion

UPDATED THURSDAY, 22 JANUARY 2026

- Opinion polls over the last decade have generally shown increasing levels of support for nuclear energy.
- Polls have identified consistent demographic markers for nuclear support, in particular gender.
- It is often asserted that nuclear energy is a particularly contentious issue, but polling data does not necessarily support this.

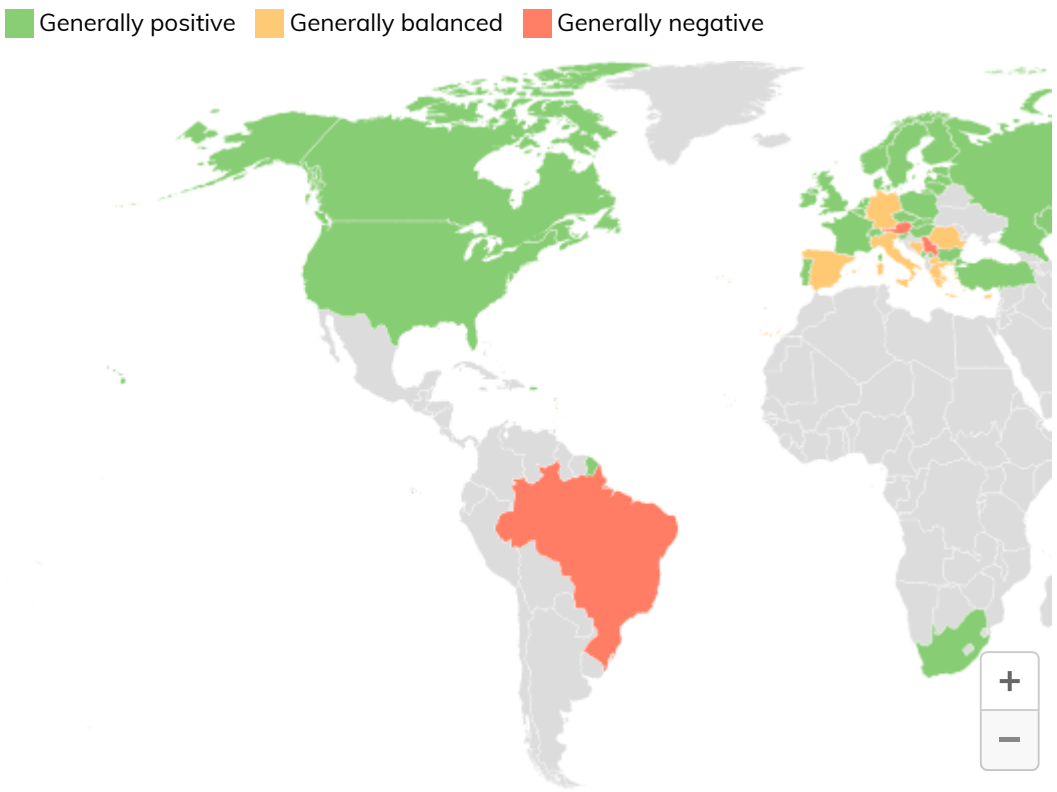
Most surveys on nuclear energy include a question that attempts to gauge overall support among respondents. Typically respondents will be asked to select an option that best describes the extent to which they support or oppose nuclear energy. The formulation of the questions varies, and so comparison between surveys should be made with caution.

Recent surveys have generally shown that more people favour the use of nuclear energy than oppose it, albeit with significant variation in the strength of net support by country.

The map below gives an indication of public sentiment towards the use of nuclear energy, and provides links to the latest polls conducted.

Nuclear Opinion Global Tracker

Privacy - Terms

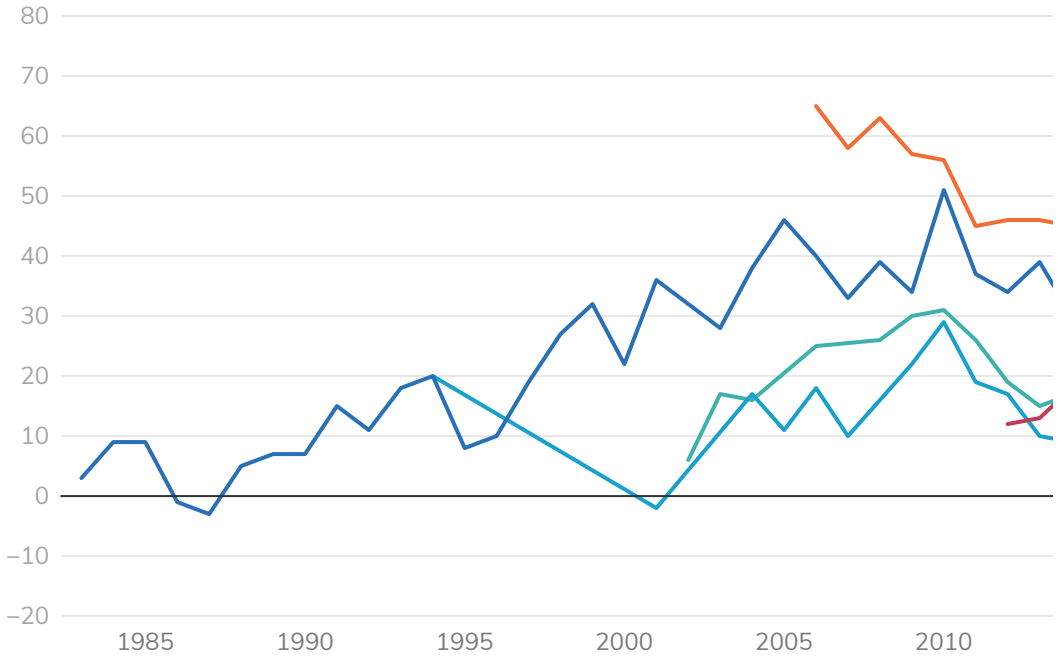


Public opinion over time

Time series data from surveys conducted at regular intervals are of particular value for understanding whether support for nuclear is rising or falling. Regular opinion polling is generally done at a national level.

Most surveys conducted at regular intervals have shown that overall support for nuclear energy has risen over the past decade.

Net support for nuclear energy (%)

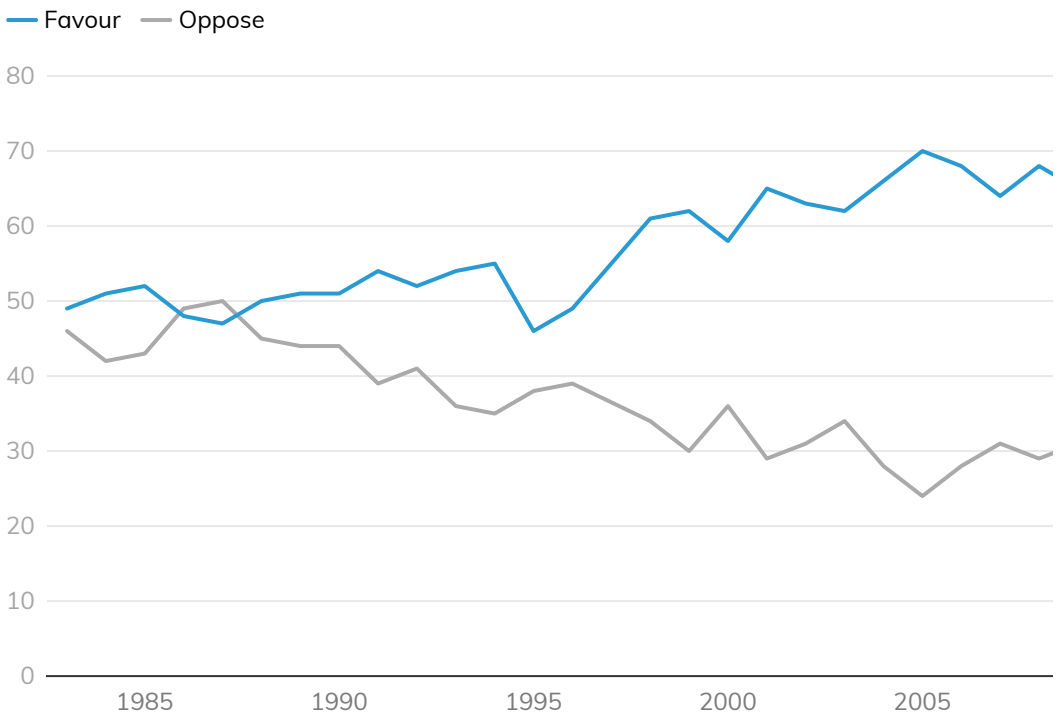


Notes: The questions posed for each included survey vary, but all ask respondents to express the extent to which they support the use of nuclear energy. Questions and possible answers are included in Notes a.

Sources: Analysgruppen[1], DESNZ Public Attitudes Tracker[2], Bisconti Research[3], Finnish Energy[4], Gallup[5], Pew Research Center[6], Századvég Project Europe[7], YouGov[8].

Bisconti Research's annual poll of public opinion in the USA is unique in its longevity. It has shown that public support for nuclear energy in the USA has steadily increased over the past 40 years. In 2024, three-quarters of respondents said they favoured the use of nuclear energy, up from about half in the 1980s and 1990s.

Support for / opposition towards the use of nuclear energy for electricity in the USA, 1983-2024 (%)



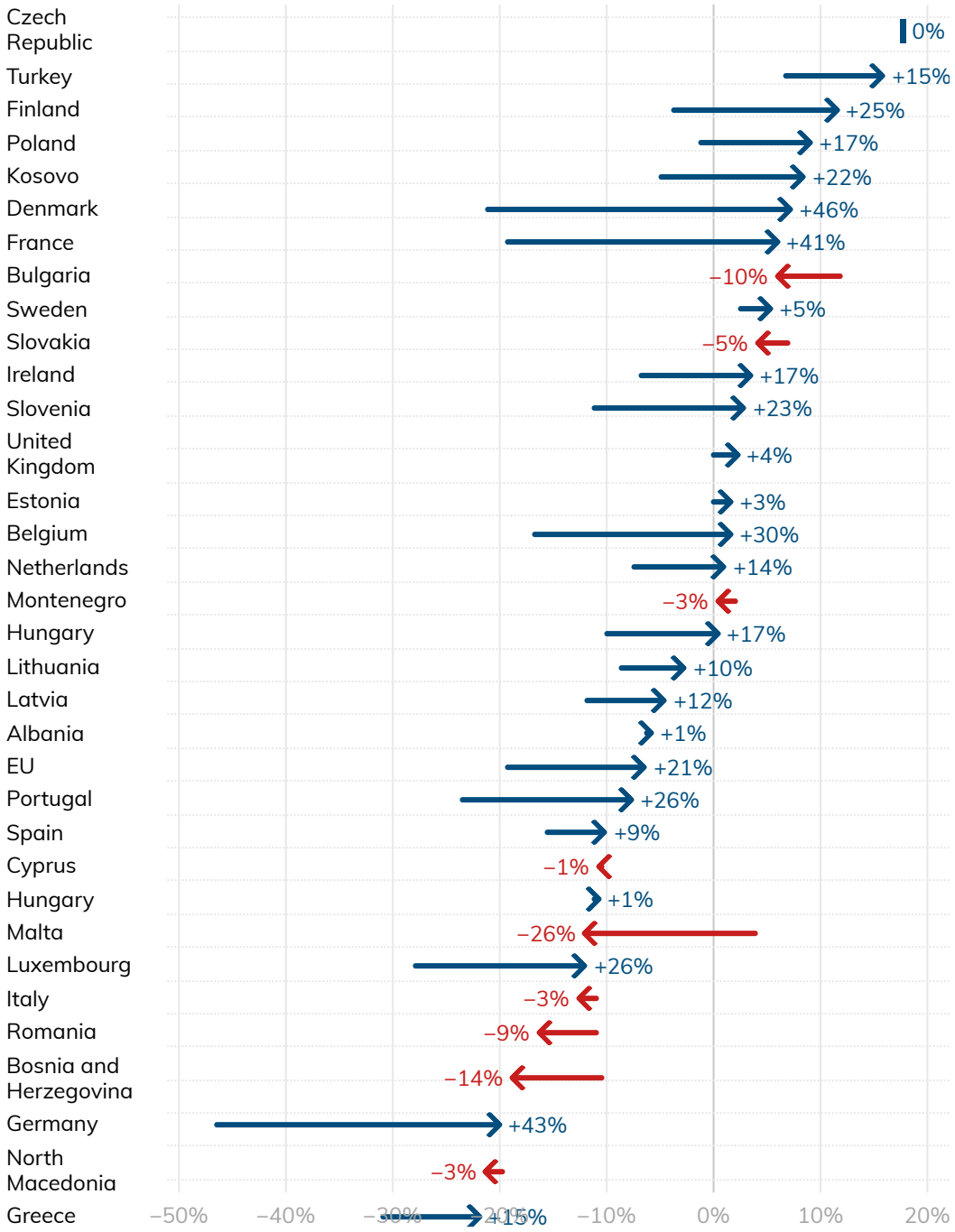
Question asked: Overall, do you strongly favor, somewhat favor, somewhat oppose, or strongly oppose the use of nuclear energy as one of the ways to provide electricity in the United States?

Source: Bisconti Research

Cross-country Eurobarometer surveys on public opinion have been conducted on behalf of European Union institutions since 1974. In 2021 and 2024 respondents to the Special Eurobarometer survey on European citizens' knowledge and attitudes towards science and technology were asked to give their views on nuclear energy.[9, 10]

In both years, respondents from a majority of countries felt nuclear energy would have a positive effect on their way of life over the next 20 years. In 24 out of 35 countries surveyed, the proportion of respondents that felt nuclear will have a positive effect over the next 20 years increased between 2021 and 2024. In the EU27, 56% of respondents in 2024 felt nuclear would have a positive effect on their way of life over the next 20 years (versus 35% negative).

Change in net views among European citizens between 2021 and 2024 on the positive or negative effect of nuclear for energy production



Question asked: Do you think nuclear energy for energy production will have a positive, a negative or no effect on our way of life in the next 20 years?

Source: Special Eurobarometer 557

Public opinion by geography

Surveys that are conducted across multiple geographies at the same time and with a consistent approach provide a useful indication of relative support for nuclear across different countries.

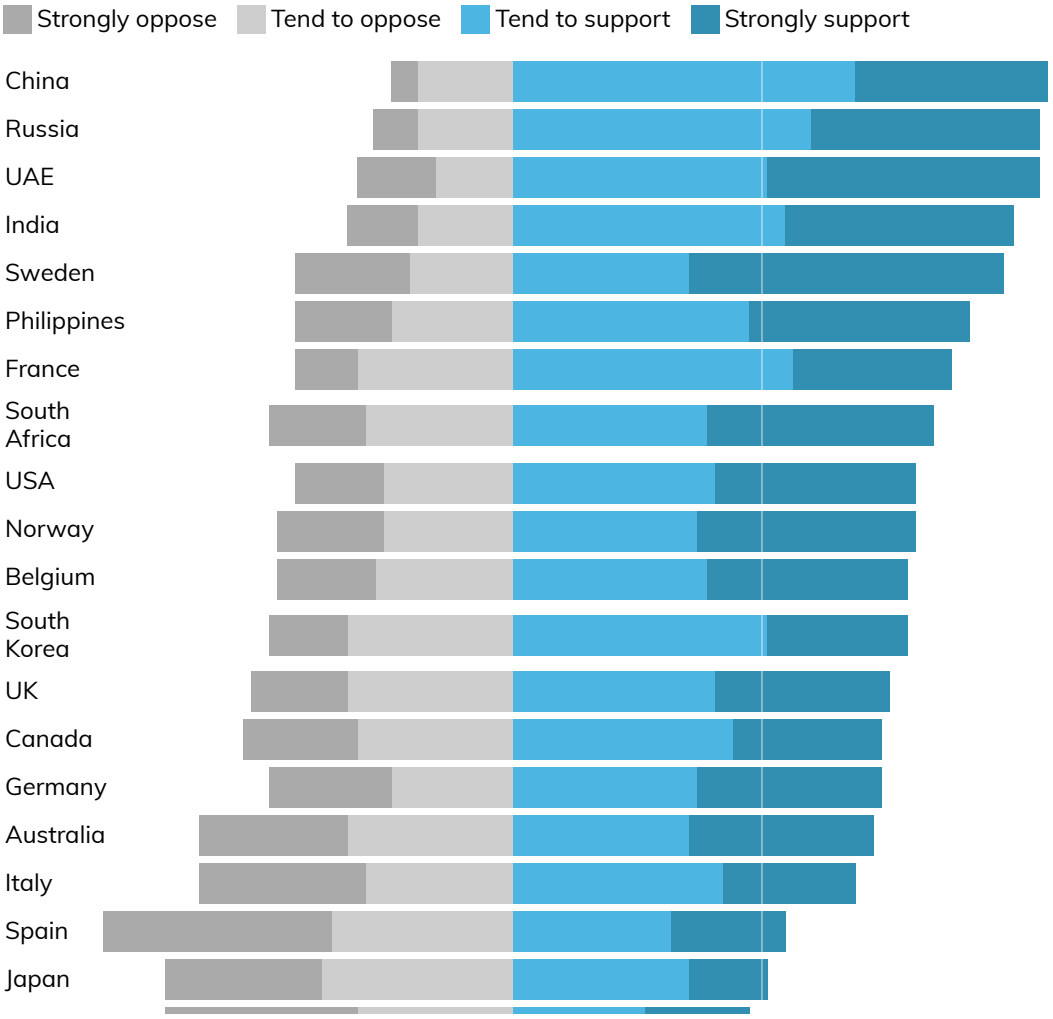
Savanta, commissioned by Radiant Energy Group, began polling for the Public Attitudes toward Clean Energy (PACE) index[11] in 2023 to

track and understand support for clean energy sources across 20 countries.

The 2023 PACE index showed that the majority of countries surveyed were net supporters of nuclear energy's use. In China, Russia, the UAE and India, the survey results showed that support for nuclear was three times higher than opposition to it. Conversely, in Japan, Brazil and Spain public opposition to nuclear exceeded support.

The survey included all G7 and BRICS countries, and found that net support for nuclear's use was 16% higher in the BRICS countries than the G7.

Support for / opposition towards the use of nuclear energy to generate electricity

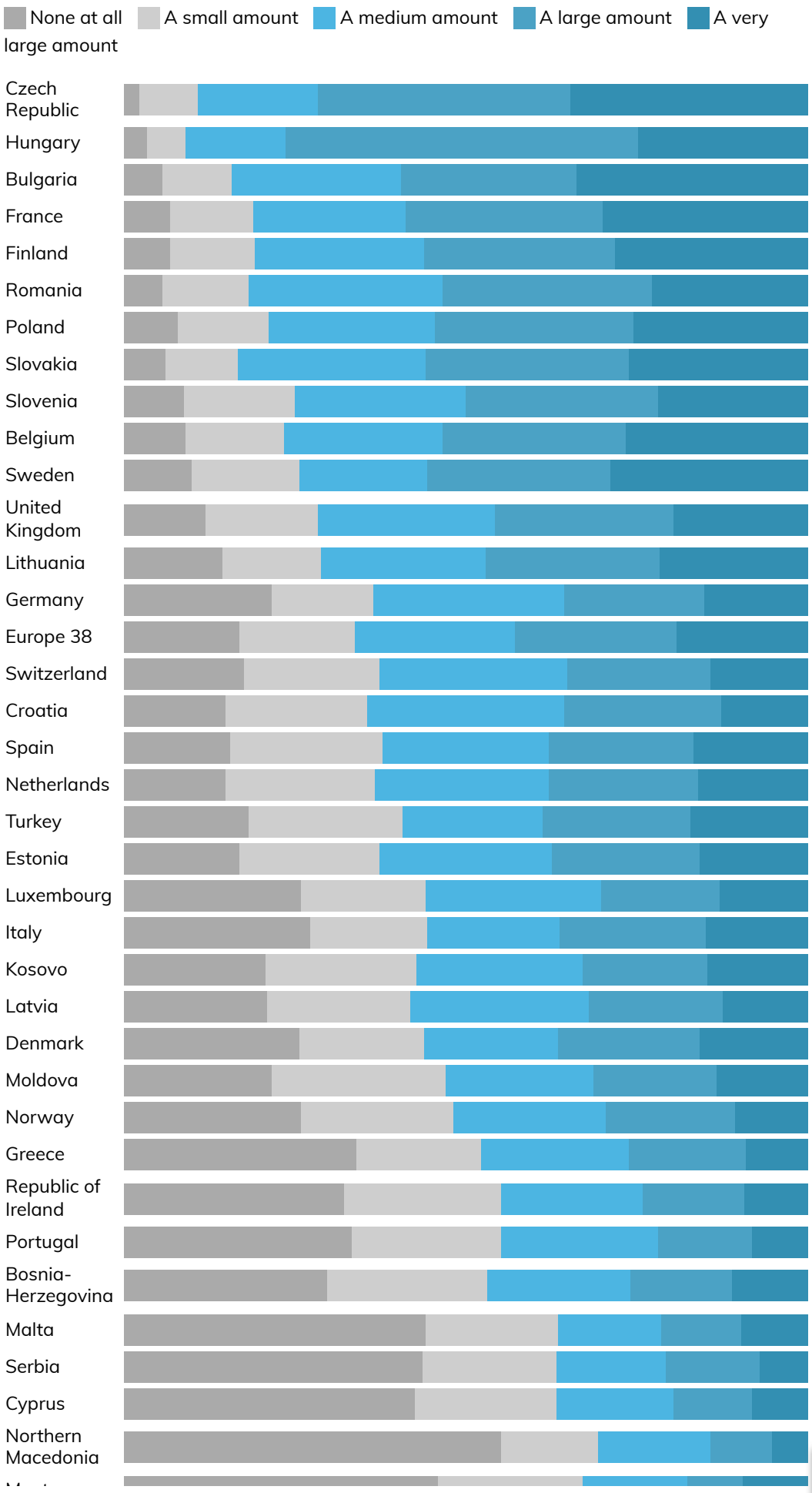


Question asked: From what you know about nuclear energy, to what extent, if at all, do you support or oppose using it to generate electricity in your country?

Source: Radiant Energy Group, PACE Index 2023

The Századvég Foundation, commissioned by the Hungarian government, has conducted research under the name of Project Europe since 2020.[7] In 27 out of 38 European countries surveyed in 2022, over 50% of respondents felt their countries should generate either 'a medium amount', 'a large amount' or 'a very large amount' of electricity from nuclear power. In just two surveyed countries (North Macedonia and Austria) did a majority of respondents feel that no electricity should be generated from nuclear power.

Views on how much electricity should be generated from nuclear power


None at all
A small amount
A medium amount
A large amount
A very large amount
Czech Republic
Hungary
Bulgaria
France
Finland
Romania
Poland
Slovakia
Slovenia
Belgium
Sweden
United Kingdom
Lithuania
Germany
Europe 38
Switzerland
Croatia
Spain
Netherlands
Turkey
Estonia
Luxembourg
Italy
Kosovo
Latvia
Denmark
Moldova
Norway
Greece
Republic of Ireland
Portugal
Bosnia-Herzegovina
Malta
Serbia
Cyprus
Northern Macedonia

Question asked: How much electricity do you think should be produced in a nuclear power plant for your country's energy consumption?
Source: Hungarian Government, Századvég Project Europe

Public opinion by demographic

Surveys have shown striking and generally consistent differences in nuclear views among different demographic groups. It is difficult to ascertain the underlying causes of such differences as factors intersect and there is a lack of available data to examine their relative importance.

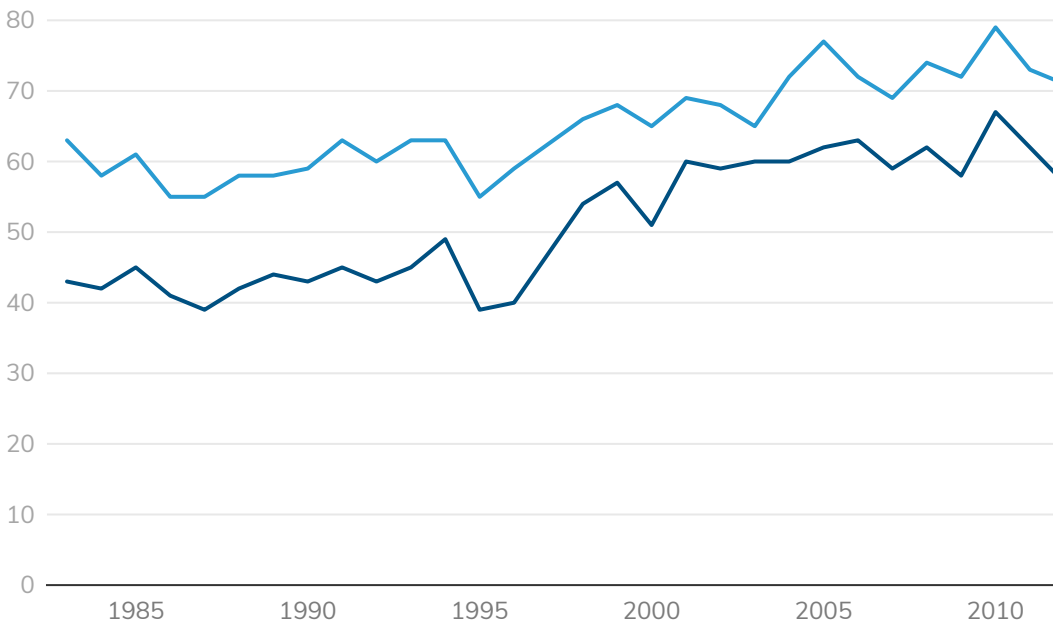
Gender

Surveys have consistently shown that men are more likely than women to favour the use of nuclear energy. Gender has generally been found to be the best demographic marker of support for nuclear; the gap in support between genders has generally been found to be larger than those found between different political, ideological or educational segments of the population.

In December 2024 a national poll of 6000 Australians revealed a stark gender divide on nuclear energy across the country; just 26% of women surveyed felt nuclear energy would be good for Australia compared with 51% of men.[12] Similarly, across all 20 countries surveyed in the 2023 PACE Index, more men support nuclear than women.[11] These results are consistent with many earlier studies.

Bisconti Research's polling[3] has shown that net support for nuclear among both men and women in the USA has trended upward since 1989, but that over this period net support among women has consistently been 10-20% lower than among men.

Proportion of men and women that support the use of nuclear energy in the United States, 1983-2024 (%)



Question asked: Overall, do you strongly favor, somewhat favor, somewhat oppose, or strongly oppose the use of nuclear energy as one of the ways to provide electricity in the United States?

Source: Bisconti Research

A number of explanations have been put forward for the gender divide in support for nuclear, but there is limited evidence to determine their validity or relative importance:

- Risk aversion: it is often asserted that women are relatively risk adverse, and that this is reflected in their views on the use of nuclear energy.
- Trust in institutions: there is some evidence that women are generally less trusting of the institutions that manage nuclear energy, such as governmental bodies and energy corporations.
- Exposure to STEM (science, technology, engineering, and mathematics) fields: in most countries, men are more likely to have exposure to STEM fields during education.
- Cultural and political factors: in some societies, women are more likely than men to align with ideologies and movements that oppose nuclear energy.

Bisconti Research has observed:[13]

- Women are predominantly 'fence-sitters'.

- Women feel uninformed on the topic, are open-minded, and are impressed by facts.
- Men feel better informed than women and are more sceptical of facts that differ from their preconceived notions.
- Both are changeable, women more so.

Irrespective of differences in overall support, Bisconti Research has found that men and women value the same things most: affordability, reliability and clean air.

Age

Age has generally been found to be a poor predictor of support for nuclear energy.

An OECD Nuclear Energy Agency (NEA) report from 2010 concluded, based on results from a 2007 Eurobarometer poll,[14] that "nuclear energy is supported more by... those who are older".[15] More recent surveys have suggested the picture is more complex.

Bisconti Research's 2024 survey found that the proportion of baby boomers (born 1946-1964) and millennials (1981-1996) that expressed strong support for nuclear energy was higher (36% and 35% respectively) than Gen Z (1997-2012) and Gen X (1965-1980) (26% and 24% respectively).

The 2023 PACE Index also found that age was a poor indicator of nuclear support. In Russia, Belgium, South Korea, France and Australia, older demographics were those most supportive of nuclear energy's use. In Brazil, South Africa, Philippines and India the opposite was true, with young demographics most likely to express strong support.

Politics

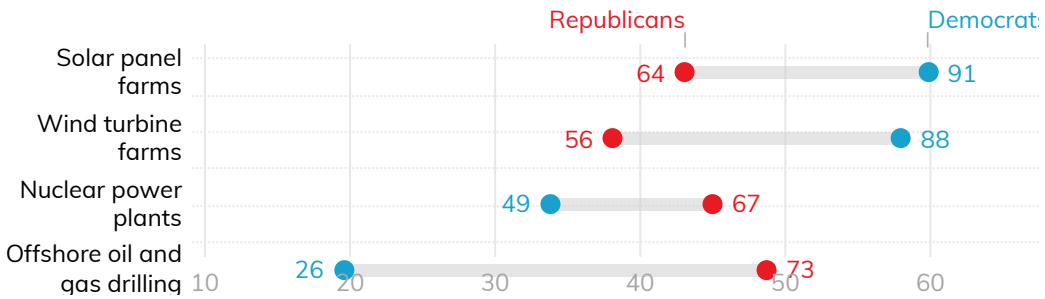
Polls have consistently shown that support for nuclear energy tends to be strongest amongst right-leaning voters.

Bisconti Research's 2024 survey found that 85% of self-identified Republicans strongly or somewhat favoured nuclear energy, compared with 78% of self-identified Democrats and 71% of independents.

The 2023 PACE Index found a clear correlation between support for nuclear energy and political views.

However, whilst an individual's political views provide a good predictor of their views on nuclear energy, it is not necessarily a particularly politically contentious issue. There is some evidence to suggest that the spread in support for nuclear across the political spectrum is less wide than for other energy sources. A 2024 Pew Research Center survey[6] showed that the difference in net support between Democrats and Republicans was smaller for nuclear than any other surveyed energy source.

Support among Republicans and Democrats for the expanded use of different energy sources



Question asked: Do you favour or oppose more nuclear power plants to generate electricity in our country?

Source: Pew Research Center

Reverse nimbyism

Polls have consistently found strong support for nuclear energy among communities that host nuclear energy facilities.

In 2024 an Ipsos poll conducted on behalf of Canadian nuclear operator Bruce Power found strong local support for the company and its nuclear power plant.[16] Findings from the survey include:

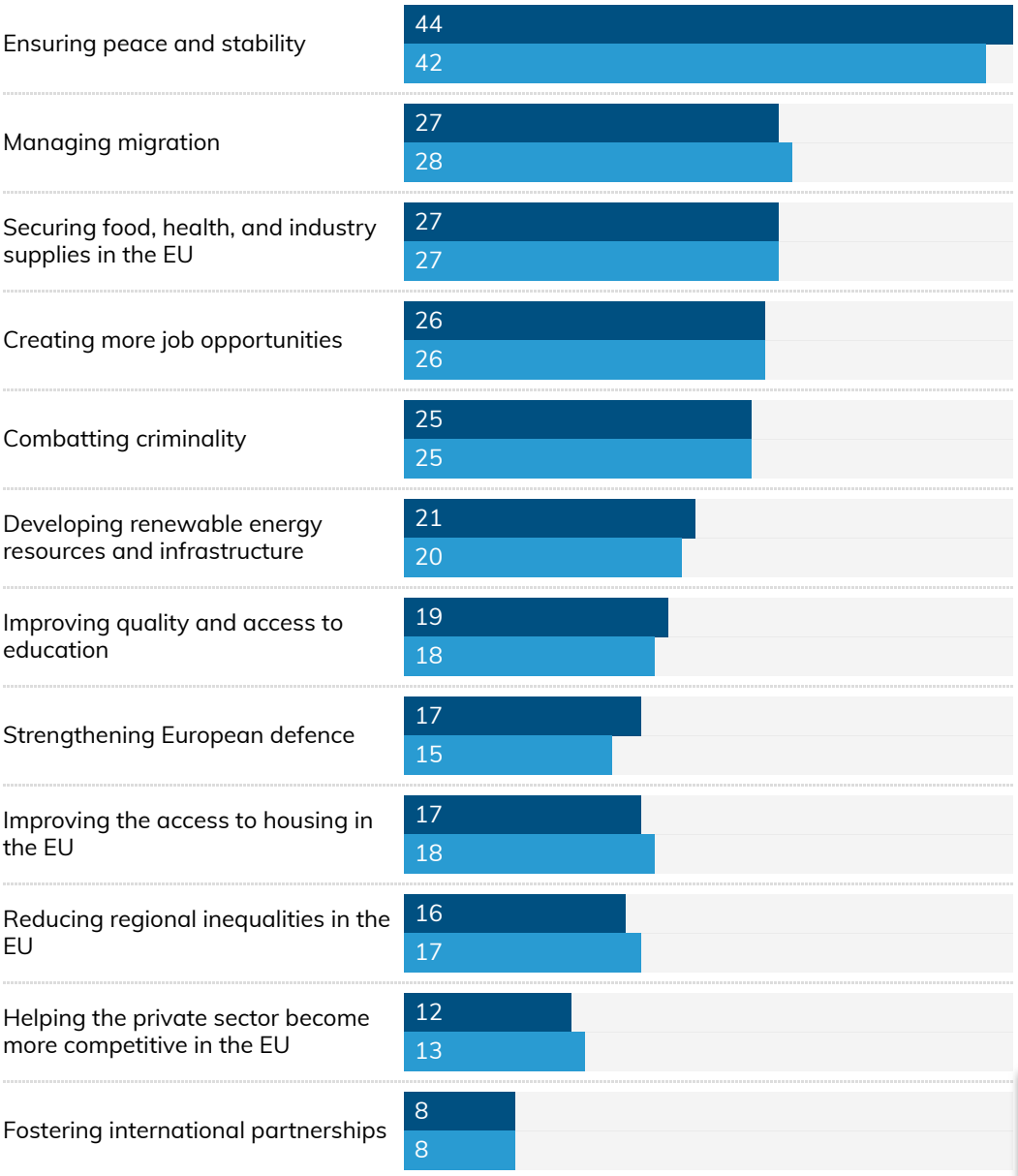
- 93% of residents familiar with Bruce Power regard it as a 'good community citizen'.
- 86% of residents support, and 53% strongly support, upgrading and refurbishing existing nuclear power plants.
- 93% of residents have confidence the Bruce facility operates safely.

Bisconti Research has found that support is consistently higher among local communities than the general public. In 2022 Bisconti's survey of residents living near US nuclear power plants showed that 88% held positive opinions on nuclear energy compared with 77% among the public in general.

What matters to the public

Energy-related issues have modest relative importance for most people. In the most recent Standard Eurobarometer surveys, respondents have identified peace and stability, migration, security of food, health and industry supplies, and job opportunities as their most important short-term priorities.[17]

Short-term priorities of European Union citizens



Question asked: Which of the following actions at the EU level do you think would have the highest positive impact on your life in the short term, *i.e.* in the next year?

Source: Standard Eurobarometer 102 - Autumn 2024

Among energy-related issues specifically, survey results from the European Union suggest that most people care about the outcomes of energy policy, rather than energy policy itself. In the most recent Eurobarometer survey of European's attitudes towards energy policies, 40% of respondents across the 27 European Union countries stated that energy prices should be the top priority of European Union energy policy.[18]

Energy policy priorities for European Union citizens

	EU27	AT	BE	BG	CY	CZ
Ensuring more affordable energy prices for consumers	40	38	42	43	47	35
Investing in innovative energy technologies	33	28	28	30	34	23
Decreasing energy consumption across Europe e.g. insulating homes or making products more energy-efficient	30	29	27	27	38	28
Coordinating European countries on energy matters	27	36	24	17	25	21
Improving energy infrastructure between and across European countries	27	30	27	24	23	22
Driving European climate neutrality	25	32	24	16	17	15
Preventing electricity blackouts and energy shortages	22	34	24	29	15	20
Ensuring nuclear energy is safe and secure	21	20	27	22	19	28
Supporting countries outside the European Union in moving to clean energy systems	16	17	14	13	13	11

Question asked: What does a European Union energy policy mean to you?

Source: Special Eurobarometer 555

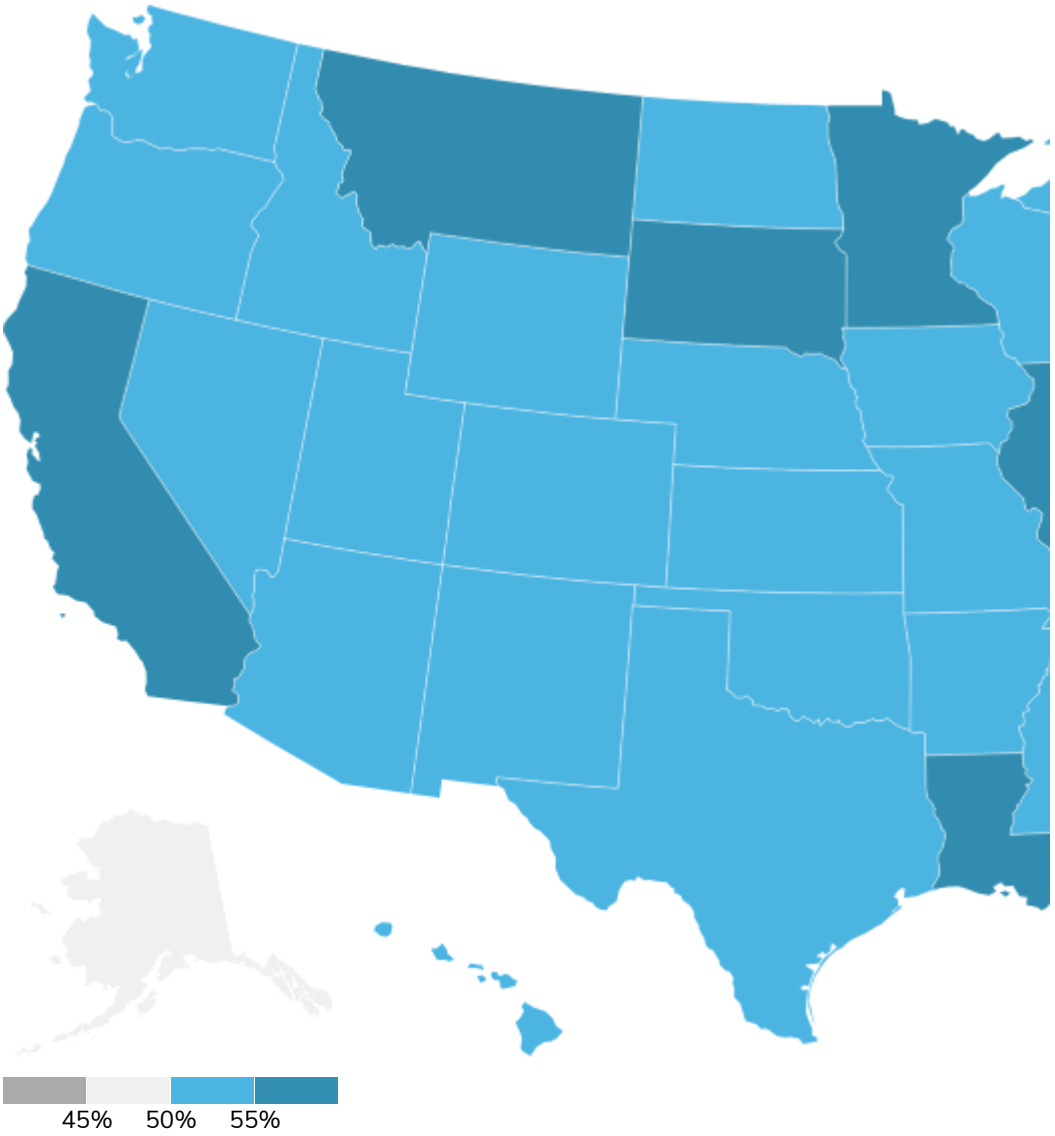
Social media sentiment analysis

Social media sentiment analysis is a method of gauging public opinion by analyzing text data from social media posts. Using natural language processing (NLP) and machine learning algorithms, assessments of the tone, attitude, and content of online discussions are made, typically categorizing sentiment as positive, negative, or neutral.

Supposed advantages over traditional polling include: real-time insights; larger and more diverse sampling; and lower costs.

University of Michigan researchers analyzed 1.26 million social media posts mentioning nuclear energy on X (formerly Twitter) between 2008 and 2023.[19] They found that most comments on nuclear energy were neutral or positive. Posts frequently cited nuclear's environmental benefits, safety improvements, and energy reliability. Negative comments were primarily centred on concerns about radioactive waste management and plant safety.

Proportion of tweets about nuclear energy with predominantly positive sentiment, 2008-2023



Source: Hwang Kwon et al. (2024)

References & Notes

Notes

a. The questions posed to respondents for each included survey vary, but all asked respondents to express the extent to which they support the use of nuclear energy. Specific questions and possible answers for each survey were:

Analysgruppen
Question: What is your personal opinion about the future use of nuclear power as an energy source in Sweden? Shall we...
Answers: ...keep using the existing reactors and if needed build new ones; ...keep using the existing reactors but do not build any new

ones; ...phase out nuclear power through political decisions; hesitant/don't know.

DESNZ Public Attitudes Tracker
Since Spring 2023 the Public Attitudes Tracker (PAT) has been conducted by the Department for Energy Security and Net Zero (DESNZ); previously, it was conducted by the former Department for Business, Energy and Industrial Strategy (BEIS) and before then, from March 2012 to summer 2016, by the Department of Energy and Climate Change (DECC).

Question: From what you know, or have heard about using nuclear energy for generating electricity in the UK, do you support or oppose its use?
Answers: strongly support; support; neither support nor oppose; oppose; strongly oppose; don't know/no opinion.

Bisconti Research
Question: Overall, do you strongly favor, somewhat favor, somewhat oppose, or strongly oppose the use of nuclear energy as one of the ways to provide electricity in the United States?
Answers: strongly favor; somewhat favor; somewhat oppose; strongly oppose.

Finnish Energy
Question: What is your perception of nuclear power as an energy source?
Answers: fully positive; mainly positive; mainly negative; fully negative.

Gallup
Question: Overall, do you strongly favor, somewhat favor, somewhat oppose or strongly oppose the use of nuclear energy as one of the ways to provide electricity for the U.S.?
Answers: strongly favor; somewhat favor; somewhat oppose; strongly oppose.

Pew Research Center
Question: Do you favor or oppose more nuclear power plants to generate electricity in our country?
Answers: favor; oppose.

Századvég Project Europe
Question: How much electricity do you think should be produced in a nuclear power plant for your country's energy consumption?
Answers: a very large amount; a large amount; a medium amount; a small amount; none at all; I have not heard of this energy source; refusal; don't know.

YouGov
Question: Generally speaking, do you support or oppose the use of nuclear power generation?
Answers: strongly support; tend to support; tend to oppose; strongly oppose; not sure.

References

1. Analysgruppen, conducted by Novus, Swedish public opinion on the use of nuclear power (2006-2024)
2. Department for Energy Security and Net Zero (DESNZ), Public Attitudes Tracker (2012-2024)
3. Bisconti Research, National Nuclear Energy Public Opinion (1983-2024)
4. Finnish Energy, conducted by Verian, Opinions on Nuclear (2002-2024)
5. Gallup, Gallup Poll Social Series: Environment (1994-2024)
6. Pew Research Center, How Americans View National, Local and Personal Energy Choices (2016-2024)
7. Hungarian Government, conducted by Századvég, Project Europe (2021-2024)
8. YouGov, Support for nuclear power (2019-2024)
9. European Union, Special Eurobarometer 516, European citizens' knowledge and attitudes towards science and technology (2021)
10. European Union, Special Eurobarometer 557, European citizens' knowledge and attitudes towards science and technology (2024)
11. Radiant Energy Group, conducted by Savanta, Public Attitudes toward Clean Energy (PACE) Index (2023)
12. Australian Conservative Foundation, conducted by DemosAu, The gender divide on nuclear energy (2024)
13. Bisconti Research, Understanding and Bridging the Gender Gap (2024)
14. European Union, Special Eurobarometer 262, Energy Technologies: Knowledge, Perception, Measures (2007)
15. OECD Nuclear Energy Agency, Public Attitudes to Nuclear Power, NEA No. 6859 (2010)
16. Bruce Power, conducted by Ipsos, Public Opinion Polling (2024)
17. European Union, Standard Eurobarometer 102 (2024)
18. European Union, Special Eurobarometer 555, Europeans' attitudes towards EU energy policy (2024)
19. Hwang Kwon *et al.*, Sentiment analysis of the United States public support of nuclear power on social media using large language models (2024)

Referenced poll details

Analysgruppen (polling by Novus), Swedish public opinion on the use of nuclear power

Type: online, national (Sweden)
Sample size: 1039
Dates of most recent survey: 23/05/2024 - 30/05/2024
Notes: Novus has surveyed Swedish public opinion of nuclear energy once a year since 2006.

Australian Conservative Foundation (polling by DemosAu), The gender divide on nuclear energy

Type: online, national
Sample size: 6709
Dates of most recent survey: 02/07/2024 - 24/11/2024

Bisconti Research, National Nuclear Energy Public Opinion Survey

Type: online, national (US)
Sample size: at least 1000
Dates of most recent survey: 30/04/2024 - 02/05/2024
Notes: Bisconti Research, Inc. has conducted the National Nuclear Energy Public Opinion Survey at least once a year since 1983.

Bruce Power (polling by Ipsos), Public Opinion Polling

Type: online, local
Sample size: 566
Dates of most recent survey: 26/09/2024 - 18/10/2024

DESNZ Public Attitudes Tracker

Type: online, national (UK)
Sample size: 3214
Dates of most recent survey: 7/11/2024 - 12/12/2024
Notes: Since Spring 2023 the Public Attitudes Tracker (PAT) has been conducted by the Department for Energy Security and Net Zero (DESNZ); previously it was conducted by the former Department for Business, Energy and Industrial Strategy (BEIS) and before then, from March 2012 to summer 2016, by the Department of Energy and Climate Change (DECC).

European Union, Standard Eurobarometer 102

Type: international
Sample size: 566
Dates of most recent survey: 10/10/2024 - 05/11/2024

European Union, Special Eurobarometer 555, Europeans' attitudes towards EU energy policy

Type: international
Sample size:
Dates of most recent survey: 22/04/2024 - 22/05/2024

European Union, Eurobarometer 557

Type: in-person interviews, international
Sample size: 26,510
Dates of most recent survey: 12/09/2024 - 10/10/2024

Finnish Energy (polling by Verian), Opinions on Nuclear

Type: telephone, national (Finland)
Sample size: 1008
Dates of most recent survey: 25/03/2024 - 05/04/2024
Notes: Verian (formerly Kantar Public) has surveyed Finnish public opinion on nuclear energy once a year since 1983.

Gallup News Service, Social Series: Environment

Type: telephone, national (US)
Sample size: c. 1000
Dates of most recent survey: 03/03/2024 - 16/03/2024
Notes: Gallup News Service has been surveying US public opinion of nuclear energy once a year since 1994.

Hungarian Government (polling by Századvég), Project Europe

Type: online, international
Sample size: 38,000
Dates of most recent survey: 13/10/2022 - 07/12/2022

Pew Research Center, How Americans View National Local and Personal Energy Choices

Type: online, national (US)
Sample size: 8638
Dates of most recent survey: 13/05/2024 - 19/05/2024

Radiant Energy Group (polling by Savanta), PACE Index

Type: online, international
Sample size: 20,122
Dates of most recent survey: 17/10/2023 - 14/11/2023

Notes: Radiant Energy Group published its Public Attitudes toward Clean Energy (PACE) index for the first time in 2023. The annual index was set up to track support for clean energy sources and in particular gather information on what drives those attitudes.

YouGov, Support for nuclear power

Type: online, national (UK)
Sample size: 1812
Dates of most recent survey: 14/10/2024
Notes: YouGov has surveyed UK public opinion on nuclear energy biannually since 2019.